it was something special and that it will be received with love, but I didn't know that I, as an artist, would receive such attention. That was a surprise."

While it was Gill's ghazal renditions on Instagram that put her on Coke Studio's radar, the show's line-up did make clear that Xulfi and his team had cast their net far wider. Not just is there something very joyful about seeing Eva B rap in an orange hijab, everything



about the Justin Bibis—right from their clothes to their lyrics—seems to have been chosen to cause delight. "Someone told them you can't sing in English because you aren't educated enough," says Xulfi. "They then learnt the lyrics of Justin Bieber's 'Baby', and when they sang it, the video went viral. That's how I saw them—confident, passionate and resilient."

Abdullah Siddiqui, an associate music producer on the show, says that even though Season 14 has made the show more relevant for Pakistan's youth, that was never the express intention. "We just wanted to make something that was a holistic snapshot of all the different kinds of music across the country. And in doing so, we did end up capturing a lot of the youth because the youth make a huge demographic. Our real aim, though, was to make something universal enough that could transcend these age demographics."

The song 'Go' gave Siddiqui, 21, an opportunity to perform with Atif Aslam, 39, one of Pakistan's most popular musicians. Like many of the tracks in this season, it is hard to pin the bilingual (English and Urdu) 'Go' down to a genre. Siddiqui says, "With the songs I produced and the one I performed, I wanted to take this vast lexicon of *desi* music and deconstruct it, retool it. I wanted to also see if I could usher in a new tradition of electronic music that was global but also very Pakistani."

With one of its singers, Arooj Aftab, having won a Grammy this year, this season of Coke Studio seems to underscore an obvious point: Pakistani music has never been more international. "Our bigger vision was to showcase the progressive and artistic side of Pakistan," says Xulfi, "but when I see the response from people all across the world, I start to feel even more strongly that it is the listeners who make music universal." Hasan Raheem, whose 'Peechay Hutt' is doubtlessly this season's best headbanger, says, "To spread different emotions through your song to people living far away from you... Who wouldn't be happy?"

Even though Xulfi calls Coke Studio an "export", it is also sometimes a template. While India's appropriation was largely lacklustre, the recent premiere of Bangladesh's Coke Studio Bangla leaves one feeling more hopeful. The three episodes of the first season seem to borrow the free-wheeling energy of its Pakistani counterpart, but making a comparison might well be missing the point. As Xulfi says, "We just need to keep our egos aside and make a music that the world can think of as its own." ■

–Shreevatsa Nevatia

GREATEST HITS

How Coke Studio took South Asia by storm



'ALIF ALLAH'
Coke Studio Pakistan
(Season 3)
Performed by folk singer Arif Lohar and pop star Meesha Shafi in 2010, it was this song which made the world sit up and take notice of a musical revolution brewing in Pakistan. Though unusual, the collaboration hit all the right notes, paving the way for several more such juxtapositions.



'NASEK NASEK'
Coke Studio Bangla
(Season 1)
A new entrant but no amateur, Bangladesh's Coke Studio released on February 23 this year. Its first song already has over 10 million views on YouTube. Featuring Animes Roy and Pantho Kanai, the track checks many boxes–danceability, diversity, delight.

'KATTEY'
Coke Studio India
(Season 3)
Most listeners agree that it was with this song that Coke Studio's Indian chapter peaked. Composed by Ram Sampath, 'Kattey' featured the Rajasthani folk powerhouse Bhanvari Devi and rapper Hard Kaur. Together, they created a track which mixed a lover's longing with feminist assertion.

